

renovation plans. At the end of the day, a second bedroom would never compensate for the house's other deficiencies: middle unit, no front yard, no parking, pests. No matter how much money she spent on the house, at a certain point, it was what it was: a little saltbox in an alley behind a restaurant. She'd never get her money out of that house, so she stopped pouring money into it and sold for a tidy profit.

10. **Sell.** Before you spend a dime on renovations, consider putting your house on the market as is, especially if it's a seller's market and you have a lot of equity in your home. But do a little remodeling and staging. In the bathroom, keep it simple: Paint the walls, regrout, install a new toilet seat and shower curtain. Replace kitchen cabinet doors only, and maybe put in stainless-steel appliances—but buy them used and refurbished at a fraction of the cost. Sometimes that's all you need to do to make the sale.